



INDIAN SOCIETY

MODULE - 4

TRIBES IN INDIAN SOCIETY

INDIAN SOCIETY

INTRODUCTION

1 Term Tribe was a modern term introduced in the colonial era.

2 Use of a single term for a very disparate set of communities was more a matter of administrative convenience.

3 Government of India Act of 1935 gave legal recognition to the lists or 'schedules' of tribes marked out for special treatment by the state. And hence the terms 'Scheduled Tribes'

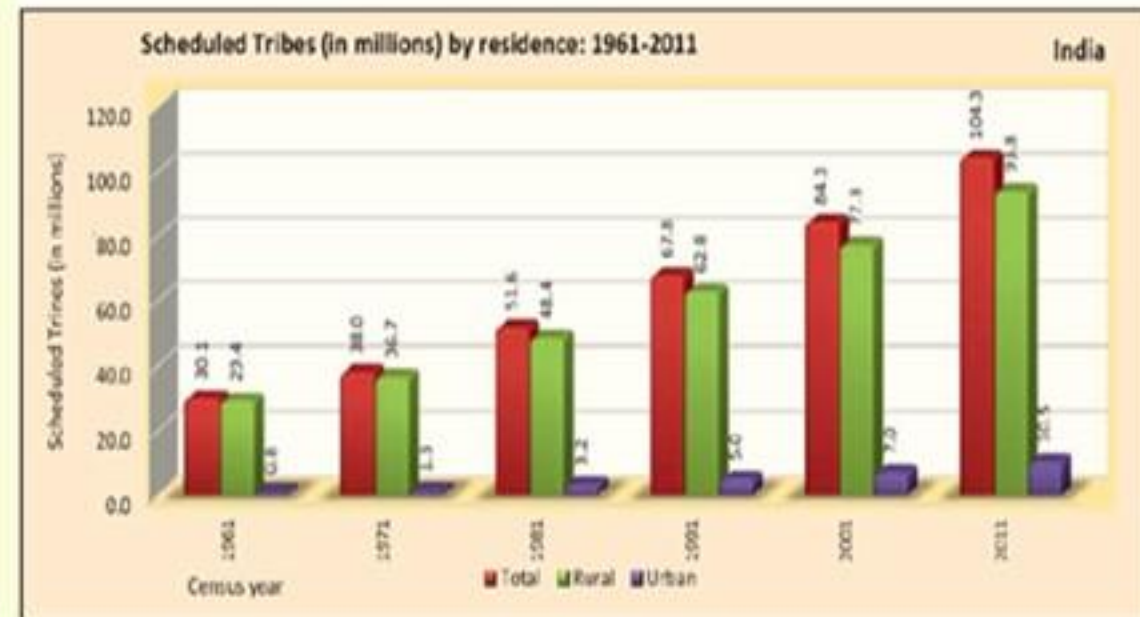


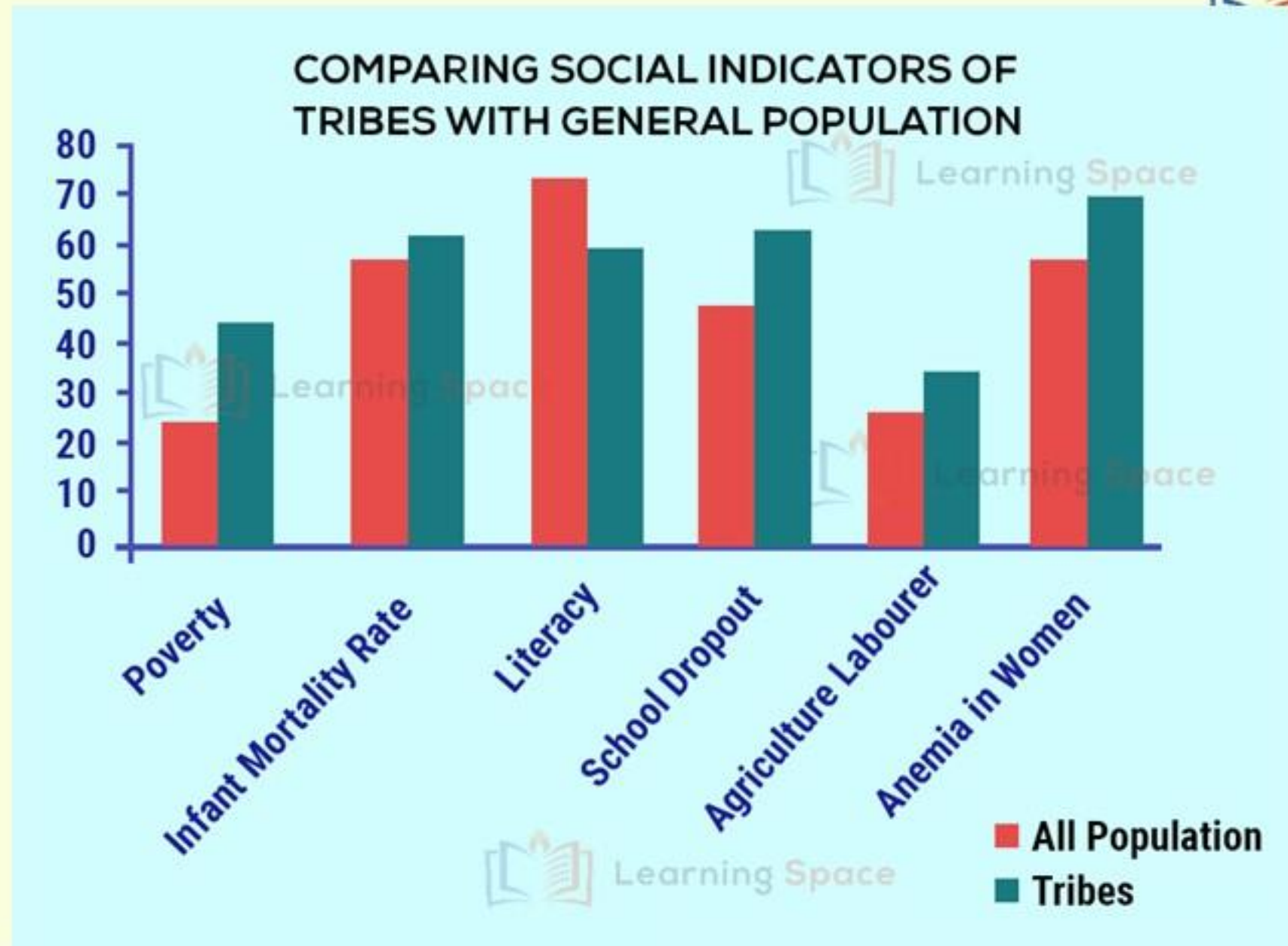
INDIAN SOCIETY

INTRODUCTION

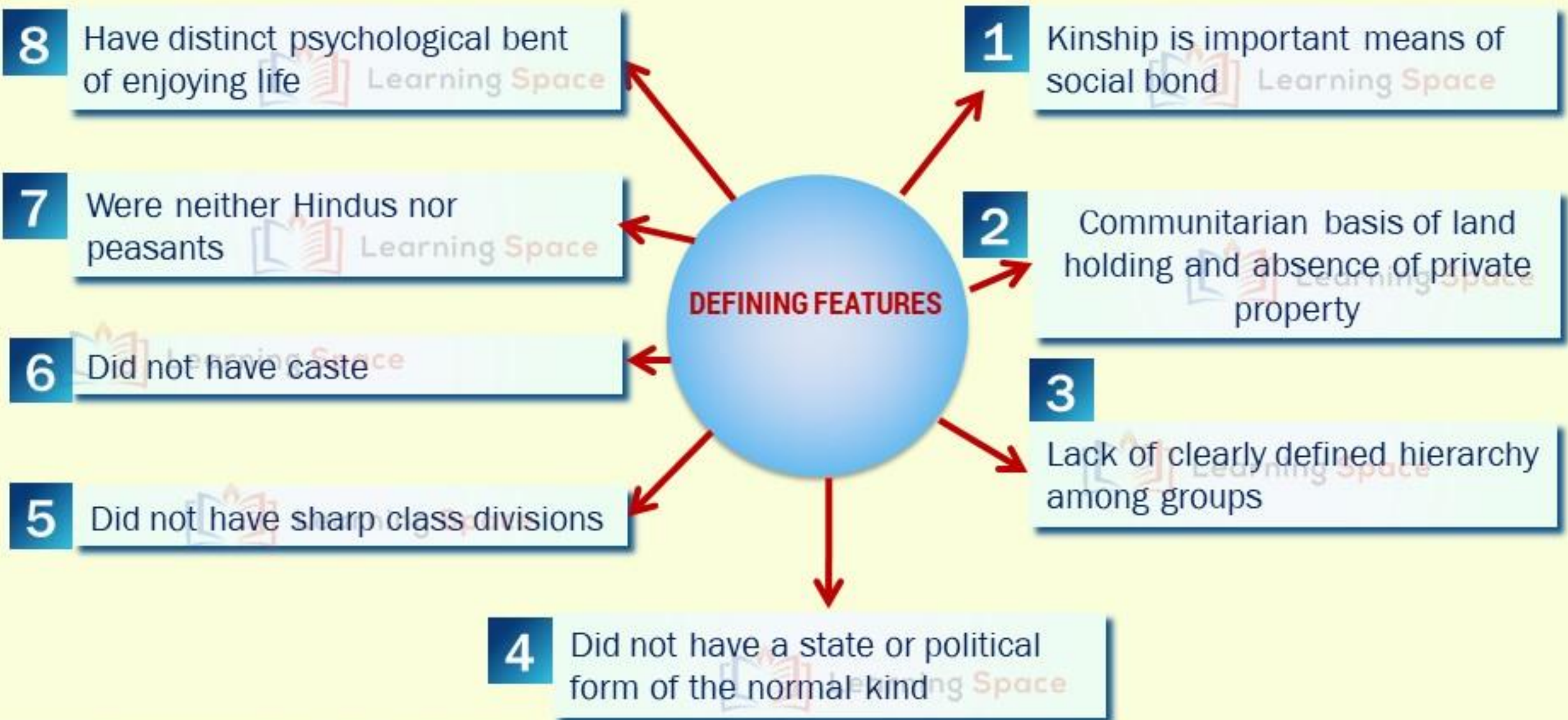
- 4 There are over 700 scheduled tribes notified under Article 342.
- 5 They constitute 8.6% of India's population.
- 6 Have their own problems distinct from main stream problems – Land and Forest alienation, indebtedness, displacement, health problems and insurgency are some of them.
- 7 As per 2011 census:
 - Sex ratio in tribals in India – 990
 - Poor literacy rate – 59 %
 - School dropout rate is more than 60%.

Scheduled Tribe population and decadal change by residence : PERSONS





DEFINING FEATURES RATHER THAN A FIXED DEFINITION



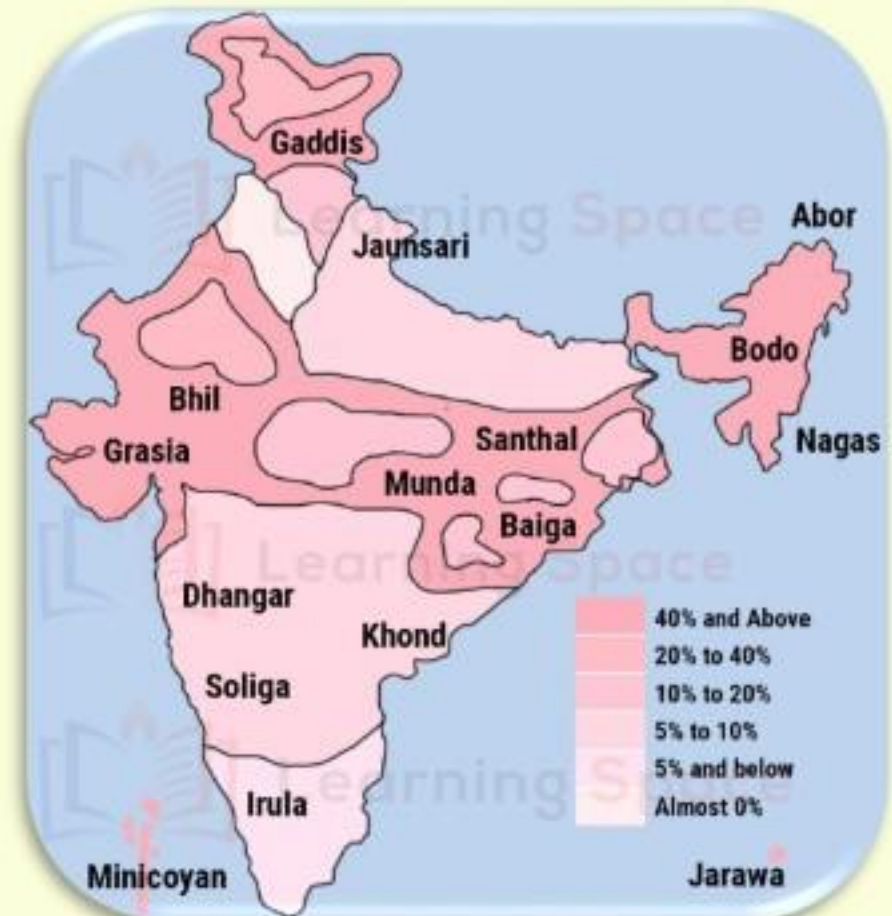
CLASSIFICATIONS OF TRIBAL SOCIETIES

Based on Permanent traits which include region, language, physical characteristics.

1. REGIONAL DISTRIBUTION

1 About 85% of the tribal population lives in 'middle India', a wide band stretching from Gujarat and Rajasthan in the west to West Bengal and Odisha in the east, with Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, Chattisgarh and parts of Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh forming the heart of this region.

2 Of the remaining 15%, over 11% is in the North Eastern states, leaving only a little over 3% living in the rest of India.



Based on Permanent traits which include region, language, physical characteristics.

1. REGIONAL DISTRIBUTION

3 If we look at the share of tribals in the state population, then the North Eastern states have the highest concentrations, with all states, except Assam, having concentrations of more than 30%, and some, like Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Mizoram and Nagaland with more than 60% and upto 95% of tribal population



4

5

6

7

8



CLASSIFICATIONS OF TRIBAL SOCIETIES

2. LANGUAGE

Tribes are categorized into four categories

- 1 Two of them, Indo-Aryan and Dravidian, are shared by the rest of the Indian population as well, and tribes account for only about 1% of the former and about 3% of the latter.
- 2 Other two language groups, the Austric and Tibeto-Burman, are primarily spoken by tribals, who account for all of the first and over 80% of the second group.



INDO-ARYAN



DRAVIDIAN



THE AUSTRIC



TIBETO-BURMAN

CLASSIFICATIONS OF TRIBAL SOCIETIES

3. PHYSICAL - RACIAL TERMS

Tribes are classified under the Negrito, Australoid, Mongoloid, Dravidian and Aryan categories. The last two are again shared with the rest of the population of India



NEGRITO



AUSTRALOID



MONGOLOID



DRAVIDIAN



ARYAN

ASSIMILATION

- 1** A process of cultural unification and homogenization by which newly entering or subordinate groups lose their distinctive culture and adopt the culture of the dominant majority.
- 2** Assimilation may be forced or voluntary, and usually remains incomplete or blocked where the subordinate or entering group is not accorded full membership on equal terms.
- 3** The argument for tribe-caste distinction was founded on an assumed cultural difference between Hindu castes, with their beliefs in purity and pollution and hierarchical integration, and 'animist' tribals with their more egalitarian and kinship based modes of social organization.



COLONIALISM AND TRIBES

BRITISH POLICY

- 1) Isolation of Tribals from mainstream
 - Administrative segregation by creating excluded area through 1919 and 1935 acts
- 2) Interested in civilizing the tribes – White Man's Burden
- 3) Attempts to bring tribes under their revenue administration
- 4) Exploitation of forests and tribal lands
 - Forest acts since 1865, deprived tribes of their livelihood and traditional rights
 - This continued till Forest Rights act 2006 was enacted
 - Even activities like cattle grazing, collection of fuel wood were made illegal and had to pay tax in permitted regions
 - Alienation is not only economic but also emotional and cultural
 - Middle Men , Money lenders and Indebtedness added to the suffering



ISOLATION AND AUTONOMY VERSUS INTEGRATION IN CONSTITUENT ASSEMBLY

- 1** Isolationist side argued that tribals needed protection from traders, moneylenders and Hindu and Christian missionaries, all of whom were intent on reducing tribals to detribalized landless labor.
- 2** Integrationists, on the other hand, argued that tribals were merely backward Hindus, and their problems had to be addressed within the same framework as that of other backward classes.

- 3** Settled along the lines of a compromise which advocated welfare schemes that would enable controlled integration



VS



TRIBAL PANCHSHEEL

NEHRU GAVE HIS FIVE FUNDAMENTAL PRINCIPLES
FOR TRIBAL DEVELOPMENT

- Non-imposition: - People should develop along the lines of their own genius, and the imposition of alien values should be avoided.
- Tribal rights in land and forest should be respected.
- Teams of tribal's should be trained in the work of administration and development. Introducing too many outsiders into tribal territory should be avoided.
- Tribal areas should not be over administered or overwhelmed with a multiplicity of schemes
- Results should be judged not by statistics or the amount of money spent, but by the human character that is evolved.



NATIONAL DEVELOPMENT VERSUS TRIBAL DEVELOPMENT

1

Schemes for tribal development under the thought of controlled integration-

- Five year plans
- Tribal sub-plans
- Tribal welfare blocks
- Special multipurpose area

2

- Integration of tribes has neglected their own needs and has been on the terms of the mainstream society.
- Ethnic tribal sub - Nationalism had emerged as a challenge

3

The tribal societies have had their lands, forests taken away and their communities shattered in the name of development.



NATIONAL DEVELOPMENT VERSUS TRIBAL DEVELOPMENT

- 4 National development, particularly in the Nehruvian era, involved the building of large dams, factories and mines.
- 5 Process of dispossessing tribals of their land has occurred as a necessary byproduct of the exploitation of minerals and the utilization of favorable sites for setting up hydroelectric power plants.
- 6
 - About 40 per cent of those displaced by dam-building belong to the Scheduled Tribes.
 - This dispossession has been a ground for Naxalism to thrive.



NATIONAL DEVELOPMENT VERSUS TRIBAL DEVELOPMENT

7 Most recent such example is the series of dams being built on the Narmada, where most of the costs and benefits seem to flow disproportionately to different communities and regions.

8 Many tribal concentration regions and states have also been experiencing the problem of heavy in-migration of non-tribals in response to the pressures of development. This disrupts and overwhelm tribal communities and cultures, besides accelerating the process of exploitation of tribals.



Industrial areas of Jharkhand for example have suffered a dilution of the tribal share of population. Similarly, in north eastern states of Tripura and Arunachal Pradesh.

TRIBAL IDENTITY TODAY

1 Tribal identities today are formed by this interactional process rather than any primordial (original, ancient) characteristics peculiar to tribes.

2 Positive impact of successes – such as the achievement of statehood for Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh after a long struggle – is moderated by continuing problems.

3 Citizens of states like Manipur or Nagaland don't have the same rights as other citizens of India because their states have been declared as 'disturbed areas'.

4 Vicious circle of armed rebellions provoking state repression which in turn fuels further rebellions has taken a heavy toll on the economy, culture and society of the North-eastern states.



- 5 Significant development is the gradual emergence of an educated middle class among tribal communities.
- 6 Most visible in the North-eastern states, this is now a segment beginning to be seen in the rest of the country as well, particularly among members of the larger tribal communities
- 7 As tribal societies get more differentiated – i.e., develop class and other divisions within themselves – different bases are growing for the assertion of tribal identity.



- 8 Two broad sets of issues have been most important in giving rise to tribal movements:
- Issues relating to control over vital economic resources like land and specially forests.
 - Issues relating to matters of ethnic-cultural identity.

- 9 The two can often go together, but with differentiation of tribal society they may also diverge.

- 10 The reasons why the middle classes within tribal societies may assert their tribal identity may be different from the reasons why poor and uneducated tribals join tribal movements.



- PVTGs are more vulnerable among the tribal groups
- Dhebar Commission (1973) created Primitive Tribal Groups (PTGs) as a separate category, who are less developed among the tribal groups
- In 2006, the Government of India renamed the PTGs as PVTGs.
- There are a total of 75 PVTGs out of 705 Scheduled Tribes.
- Basic characteristics - they are mostly homogenous, with a small population, relatively physically isolated, absence of written language, relatively simple technology and a slower rate of change etc.
- Among the 75 listed PVTG's the highest number are found in Odisha.



DE-NOTIFIED, NOMADIC AND SEMI-NOMADIC TRIBES

- 1** Criminal Tribes Acts (CTA) of 1871: About 200 communities were deemed to be 'hereditary criminals' and subject to surveillance, confinement and gross discrimination. It was in light of the then prevailing notion that crime was a genetic trait passed down from one generation to the next.
- 2** The CTA was removed from the statute books in 1952 on the recommendation of the All India Criminal Tribes Inquiry Committee (1949) and henceforth, 'Criminal Tribes' came to be known as 'De-notified Tribes' instead.
- 3** Nomadic and semi-nomadic communities practice a range of occupations-pastoralists and hunter-gatherers, mainly shepherds, cowherds and hunters of small game, entertainers including dancers, acrobats, snake charmers, monkey trainers.



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